

Goons' Own COUNTRY

With the recent killing of a top industrialist, another inglorious chapter has been added to Kerala's slide from a relatively peaceful state to a volatile crime zone

By **M.G. Radhakrishnan**

The scion of one of Kerala's richest business families and the executive director of the Rs 20,000-crore Muthoot Group, Paul M. George, 31, was quite an eligible bachelor. But at midnight of August 21 he lay dead on a deserted road near Alappuzha with stab wounds all over his body. The co-passenger in his car, R. Praveen, was admitted to hospital with injuries. Two days later, the police arrested 11 persons believed to be members of a criminal gang in connection with the murder. On August 25, a petty criminal Kari Sathish, who was arrested a day before, admitted having stabbed Paul to death. But many, including Satish's relatives, say he is being framed by the police only to shield some bigwigs. Second of the three

sons of M.G. George, chairman, Muthoot Group, and Sara George, Paul had recently shifted his business hub from Delhi to Kerala after taking over the Group's hospitality division.

According to the police, though Paul was killed by contractual killers, it was not planned. Ruling out business rivalry or an act of revenge, the police say it was the result of an altercation on the road. Their laboured theory goes like this: The Ford Endeavour that Paul was driving hit a passing motorcyclist on the Alappuzha-Changanassery road and sped away. Seeing the motorcyclist lying on the road, some other persons—all paid criminals—travelling in a van stopped and shouted at Paul to halt. But as Paul drove off, they chased him and after 2.5 km saw his car parked on the side. A scuffle ensued between the two groups,

which led to Paul's murder. By this time, Paul's driver Shibu, who was following in a Scorpio car, reached the spot along with two other men, Omprakash and Puthenpalam Rajesh, who are known criminals. Seeing the approaching car, the attackers escaped. Shibu took Paul, who was dead by then, and Praveen to a nearby hospital. In the meantime, the two men who had arrived with Shibu left from there in Paul's Ford Endeavour, which was found abandoned by the police and is said to be owned by Omprakash.

Clearly the police version lacks credibility and has deepened the mystery surrounding the sensational incident. The most glaring question is

BUSINESS RIVALRY OR AN ALTERCATION ON THE ROAD? WHAT LED TO PAUL'S MURDER REMAINS A MYSTERY

